

EG Geo-technology, United Kingdom: Eliminating science and technology department jeopardizes London's third-way tech and AI approach

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Eliminating science and technology department jeopardizes London's third-way tech and AI approach

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- * Prime Minister Andy Burnham's decision to dissolve the Department for Science, Innovation and Technology (DSIT) risks weakening the UK's leadership position on tech and AI policy, though a new AI Minister Kanishka Narayan will attend cabinet meetings, and a new AI taskforce will operate within a strengthened Number 10.
 - * Critics fear the move could signal a retreat from the UK's "third way" between the US and EU policy approaches and deprioritize the UK's innovation agenda.
 - * Unlike his immediate predecessors, Burnham risks viewing AI largely through the lens of social and labor concerns, which could weaken the pro-innovation posture that has helped the country become an emerging hub for AI development.
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DSIT's closure will fragment tech policy across multiple departments. DSIT was the government's dedicated home for tech, AI, digital infrastructure, and research policy. The government transferred these responsibilities to a newly enlarged Department for Business, Innovation, Science and Trade (DBIST). It moved digital regulation and online harms to the renamed Department for Digital, Culture, Media and Sport. Burnham named a dedicated AI minister who will attend the cabinet's meetings, but the role lacks the broader authority of a technology secretary. Other functions, such as cross-government AI deployment, will find other homes.

DSIT had a mandate to make the UK a science and technology hub through policy and standards. The department worked with industry and housed the UK Research and Innovation department, Innovate UK, the AI Security Institute (AISI), the Sovereign AI Fund, and the Government Digital Service. It had also become the global tech sector's entry point into government.

Burnham made the change despite industry objections. Trade groups warned that the move was "the wrong change at the wrong time." Government advisers warned that reorganizations distract and

disrupt. Companies fear weaker AI leadership and less coherent regulation. Without a clear point of differentiation from Brussels, some firms may decide against using the UK as their European hub.

The move risks the UK's third-way leadership on AI and technology. The UK has been lighter-touch than Brussels, and more safety- and capacity-oriented than Washington, but the move is likely to set back the UK's post-Brexit middle ground strategy. Under former prime ministers Rishi Sunak and Keir Starmer, the UK sought to position itself as closer to the technology industry and more flexible on regulation than the EU, while maintaining more institutional substance on safety, sovereignty, and governance than Washington. The AISI led global efforts on AI benchmarking, testing, and safety standards. It was a prominent and effective symbol of the UK's ambition.

After this restructuring, UK tech governance now resembles both the continental model, where technology is fragmented across multiple economic or industry ministries, and the US approach, where multiple departments centralize pieces of cross-cutting policy. The UK's approach to technology now depends on an effective AI minister and a business secretary who can effectively champion the tech brief within a mega-department also responsible for steel, trade, and industrial strategy.

Senior government sources insist that Burnham's decision that Narayan should attend cabinet is a sign of the prime minister's "deep commitment to AI's importance." They say the energetic Narayan has a good reputation in the sector and that AI requires a "whole-of-government approach" from the center. Burnham will also set up an AI taskforce in an expanded Office of the Prime Minister and Cabinet and appoint a prime ministerial adviser on AI. The Cabinet Office will lead the civil service's adoption of AI and take charge of AI strategy and public sector use, and the AISI. In Whitehall, the shake-up is seen as a victory for Antonia Romeo, the cabinet secretary, who is believed to have recommended it to Burnham.

Signs suggest DSIT's technology and AI agenda could shift away from global leadership towards social issues, and leave the tech industry without a strong institutional advocate. The AISI has established the UK as a global convening hub for AI safety and security. It developed one of the most accessible benchmarking programs for frontier models. The Sovereign AI Fund was designed to ensure the UK retained independent capacity and was not simply absorbed into the gravitational pull of US hyperscalers. DSIT, and the UK more broadly, worked closely with US vendors, sometimes raising concerns that the government was trading sovereignty for access and investment. If the transition deprioritizes the AISI, the UK will lose the ability to serve as a neutral convening ground and leader in AI governance. Critics on both the left and the right of this debate—those who thought DSIT was too industry-friendly and those who thought it was the UK's best defense against foreign capture—are now united in concern about what comes next.

Burnham's governing program may filter technology and innovation policy through a social-value lens: scrutiny on worker displacement, fairness in algorithmic decision-making, and firms' obligations to demonstrate community benefit. High-profile AI deployments or crises may become political flashpoints. Over time, that shift could move UK AI policy closer to EU-style social and labor protections, even if the formal regulatory instruments remain lighter than in the EU. Companies that chose the UK for a serious governance framework with a pro-innovation posture may need to recalibrate their expectations.

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